

PUEBLA MEXICO



Chocolate Chicken in Puebla

Just two hours from Mexico City, Puebla – the “City of Angels” – sits in a mountain valley surrounded by dramatic peaks and smoking, snow-capped volcanoes. Its gentle atmosphere owes much to its graceful colonial buildings, and visitors are kept busy photographing the magnificent architecture and eating *mole poblano* – this foodie city’s namesake dish.



Puebla’s immaculately preserved colonial architecture is arguably the best in Mexico, and has won the city UNESCO World Heritage status. Most of its 5,000 Spanish colonial buildings were built in the grand Baroque style of the 16th century, around graceful squares that found room for later additions in the 17th and 18th centuries. The magnificent cathedral dominates the main plaza, but the city also boasts the oldest library in the Americas, the Biblioteca Palafoxiana, and dozens of fascinating houses, convents, and churches. Domes crowd the skyline, pretty tiles line the walls and floors, and the gentle spray of fountains cools the many courtyards. Visitors browse for handicrafts in the markets or pottery workshops, or set off to wander the national parks, hike around the volcano, or visit the giant pyramid of Puebla’s neighboring town, Cholula.

But Puebla is also an industrialized modern city with a large university, and it has a real buzz about it. There’s a thriving café and restaurant culture, and the city is famous for its wonderful food, especially *mole*

poblano: chicken in a chili-pepper-and-chocolate sauce. This is the best-known of several *mole* (pronounced “MO-lay”) varieties and follows a complex recipe. The word *mole* comes from the indigenous ancient Aztec Náhuatl language, as do other more familiar words, such as avocado, tomato, and chocolate. *Mole* means something like “sauce”, so guacamole is a sauce of avocado. *Poblano* simply means “of Puebla.”

There are many interpretations of *mole poblano*, but the classic version comprises chicken breast covered in a voluptuous spicy sauce made of chili pepper and dark, unsweetened chocolate, subtly flavored with toasted seeds, dried fruits, corn, and spices, then left to bubble and reduce over many hours. Top of the menu at any special occasion, *mole poblano* is synonymous with celebration, starring at all weddings and on national holidays. Puebla’s countless churches regularly host jubilant ceremonies and religious processions, which spill out onto the cobbled streets, making it impossible not to get caught up in this radiant city’s colorful, joyous atmosphere.



Above A family produce stand at the weekly market in neighboring Cholula

What Else to Eat

Considered to be the gastronomic center of Mexico, Puebla has a varied cuisine that blends pre-Hispanic, Arabic, East Asian, French, and Spanish influences. Alongside *mole poblano*, other nationally and internationally renowned dishes include *chiles en nogada*, stuffed chili peppers with walnut sauce traditionally garnished with pomegranate seeds to provide the three colors of the Mexican flag – red, green, and white. Another classic is *pipián verde*, a fantastically tasty green *mole* sauce made from a base of toasted pumpkin seeds and usually served over chicken or pork. More casual street food comes from Puebla’s covered food market, where *cemitas* – Mexican sandwiches – abound, with a dizzying array of possible fillings. Cheese-lovers should make straight for the oozing, stringy delights of the *quesadillas*.

The Best Places to Eat Mole Poblano

Sacristia de la Compañía

expensive

Undoubtedly one of the most upmarket dining options in Puebla, the eclectic Sacristia de la Compañía restaurant has two intimate rooms and a large patio, and offers a tasting menu alongside the à la carte list. Find it in the attractive Callejón de los Sapos – the same location as the weekend antique and flea market – in the historic center of the city. Part of a boutique hotel and antique shop (all the pieces on display are for sale, adding to the atmosphere) and housed in an 18th-century colonial mansion, the restaurant serves the best local and regional recipes and describes its *mole poblano* as the restaurant’s “host.” The Sacristia version of the classic dish is smokier and fierier thanks to charred chipotle (a smoked jalapeño pepper). You know you’re in good hands when the chef behind a restaurant also offers cooking lessons, as this one does, lasting either one, three, or seven days. The week-long course is part of a package that includes hotel accommodations (wonderfully romantic) and meals.

6 Sur No. 304, Callejón de los Sapos; open 10 AM–10:30 PM Mon–Sat, 10 AM–5 PM Sun; www.mesones-sacristia.com

Also in Puebla

The most central of the three lively **Fonda de Santa Clara** restaurants (www.fondadesantaclara.com; *moderate*), on 3 Poniente, specializes in local dishes and ingredients, with *mole poblano* as the centerpiece, and has traditional music and decor.

Also in Mexico

Three hours south of Puebla, the beautiful colonial city of Oaxaca cannot of course boast *mole poblano* but is home to the so-called “seven *moles* of Oaxaca,” the most famous variety being *mole negro*. This should be jet-black in color due to the precise cooking (almost burning) of the ingredients. It uses six kinds of chili peppers and an array of nuts, dried fruit, seeds, and spices, as well as chocolate. The restaurant **Como Agua Pa Chocolate** (www.comoaguapachocolate.com; *moderate*), named after the Mexican novel by the same name (*Like Water for Chocolate*), has a balcony overlooking the Alameda Park, and while undoubtedly somewhat touristy, serves good chicken *mole* with a choice of five colorful Oaxacan sauces.

Around the World

Authentically prepared *mole poblano* is difficult to find outside Mexico and the southwestern United States; however, the four London branches of “market eating” restaurant chain **Wahaca** (www.wahaca.co.uk; *moderate*) do serve it enchilada-style with shredded chicken, using a recipe from Guanajuato, a picturesque town northwest of Mexico City.